

THE TALE OF THE TWO PATHS

组玮芸 Zu Weiyun Origin story

Prologue

Night had settled gently over the hidden valley. The last streaks of crimson had long since faded beyond the western peaks, and a pale moon took its place at the sky throne, surrounded by small gemstones of stars. Ancient pines whispered in the mountain wind, their dark crowns swaying like silent sentinels above the village. Between the wooden houses, warm lanterns glowed softly, while the scent of pine resin and fresh woodsmoke drifted through the cool evening air.

At the heart of the village, a great fire crackled beneath an ancient cedar whose broad branches had watched over generations of villagers.

The children gathered around the fire in an uneven half-circle. Some sat cross-legged, trying very hard to look brave. Others leaned against older brothers and sisters, clutching sweet rice cakes in their small hands.

Next to the tree sat Elder Shen.

His beard, white as winter frost, reached almost to his waist, and deep lines framed eyes that remained as clear and steady as a mountain lake. He rested both hands upon the head of a polished walking staff carved from ancient pine and waited until even the most restless child had fallen quiet.

Only then did he speak.

"My little ones," he said, his voice carrying as gently as the evening wind, "you have often heard your parents tell you that every path begins with a single step. Yet few remember that every soul, too, must one day stand where two roads part.

In the elder days, before these mountains bore the names we know today, before kingdoms rose and crumbled into dust, the Fox Spirit Clan wandered freely beneath Heaven. They dwelt among mist-veiled forests, crossed rivers that no longer flow, and cultivated in harmony with the breath of Heaven and Earth. Their illusion arts were unmatched, and spirits from distant lands sought their wisdom.

But harmony is a patient teacher, and patience is a virtue not all possess.

The world is woven from many currents of spiritual energy. Some are calm as still water, some rage like storms upon the sea, while others slumber beneath forgotten mountains or drift through abandoned places where sorrow has lingered for so long that even the stones remember it. Among those currents lies one that our ancestors came to call dark energy.

Most spirits avoided it, for they sensed its instability. They understood that to draw such power into one's soul was to invite the storm into one's own heart. But there were those among our ancestors whose curiosity exceeded their caution. They touched that which wiser spirits left untouched.

At first, the change seemed a blessing. Their cultivation advanced with astonishing speed. Illusions that once demanded years of practice answered their thoughts with ease. Some discovered they could walk unseen through the dreams of mortals, while others learned to wear the bodies of men as easily as one changes a robe. They believed they had uncovered a secret hidden from the rest of the world.

But darkness has never granted true strength. It grants certainty. It silences doubt, dulls fear, and whispers to every foolish thought, *Yes... you are right. Go farther.*

And so our ancestors did.

They mistook recklessness for courage, pride for wisdom, and power for freedom. They laughed where caution should have stayed their feet, sought conflict where peace would have served them better, and no longer weighed the lives of others with the care they once had. The darkness had not stolen their minds—it had merely convinced them they no longer needed them.

The years passed, and the darkness they had welcomed into their souls slowly welcomed itself into their flesh. Their skin darkened like stone beneath moonlight, their fur turned black as the deepest night, and even their blood was transformed until it, too, longed for the very power that had changed them. They no longer cultivated dark energy simply because they wished to; they hungered for it. What had begun as curiosity became dependence, and what had seemed a gift revealed itself to be a chain.

The Fox Spirit Clan mourned those they had lost, but the ones who had embraced darkness no longer called themselves fox spirits. They had chosen another name—the Black Fox Court. The world, however," the old man said with a faint sadness in his smile, "remembered them by a different one: "Fox Demons."

Several of the younger children instinctively edged closer together. Elder Shen noticed.

"They were not born monsters," he said quietly. "They became them, and that, little ones, is the most important lesson of all. No soul enters this world wishing to become cruel. A mountain is not climbed in a single stride, nor does a river carve a valley in a single day. So it is with the soul. One selfish choice rarely changes a person, but one selfish choice invites another, and another after that, until one day they look into still water and no longer recognize the face reflected there.

Yet this is not where our story ends.

For among the fox demons were those who finally opened their eyes. They saw not glory, but ruin; not strength, but slavery. They understood that they had mistaken intoxication for enlightenment and hunger for power. So they laid aside the path they had walked for generations and abandoned their clan, their homes, and all they had ever known. They journeyed until they found these mountains.

They could not change their blood, nor restore the color of their skin, and no power beneath Heaven could erase the darkness that had altered their very bodies. Yet there remained one thing no darkness could ever take from them—the freedom to choose. So they chose restraint over indulgence, kindness over cruelty, and responsibility over power. They taught those choices to their children, and their children passed them to the generations that followed.

That, little ones, is why we are gathered here tonight.

Remember this well. The darkness was never our greatest enemy. Our greatest enemy has always been the moment we stop questioning ourselves, for the soul that believes it can no longer be led astray has already taken the first step."

Silence settled over the clearing.

The fire crackled softly, and the wind sighed through the cedar branches overhead.

Then—

Thunk.

A pinecone landed neatly in Elder Shen's lap.

No one spoke.

The old man looked down at the pinecone, then slowly raised his eyes toward the branches above. He closed them for a brief moment, as though silently asking the ancestors for patience.

"...Zu Weiyun."

A small voice drifted down through the needles.

"...Yes, Elder?"

"I trust the view from the cedar was worth missing every perfectly good seat around the fire."

There was a thoughtful pause.

"...It was."

A few of the children snickered.

"And how long have you been up there?"

Another pause.

"...Does 'before everyone arrived' count?"

Elder Shen sighed the long, practiced sigh of a man who had known one particular child for all eight years of her life.

"Come down."

"...Must I?"

"Yes."

"...Immediately?"

"Zu Weiyun."

The branches began to rustle. A shower of pine needles drifted lazily toward the fire.

"I almost have it," Weiyun muttered.

A heartbeat later came a muffled, "Ow."

One small foot appeared beneath the branches, then disappeared again.

"I thought that branch was lower."

"It was not," Elder Shen replied.

"Oh."

More rustling followed.

"I think..." she announced with complete confidence, "...I have become tangled."

"You have."

"I was trying not to."

"So I gathered."

One of the older boys called helpfully, "Try the branch to your left!"

"I know that!"

She reached for it.

Missed.

With a startled squeak, she slipped the last few feet from the tree and landed squarely on her backside in a pile of dry needles.

For one very long heartbeat, nobody said anything.

Weiyun blinked, looked around at the circle of children staring at her, then slowly climbed to her feet. She brushed the pine needles from her robes with all the dignity an eight-year-old could possibly muster, folded her hands behind her back, and declared,

"...I was testing whether the ground was awake."

The clearing erupted into laughter.

Even Elder Shen's beard twitched with the smile he was trying very hard to suppress.

He shook his head. "One day, child, your curiosity will carry you somewhere even your poor parents cannot follow."

Weiyun looked back up into the towering cedar, her eyes sparkling with the same boundless curiosity that had already become famous throughout the village.

"...Do you think there's anything interesting at the very top?"